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### Ethical Impacts of Aggressive Marketing

Across the world, aggressive marketing has become a powerful force shaping the choices people make every day. Its influence is especially concerning when examined through current global health trends. For instance, one study reports that by the time 2030 rolls around, nearly one in three children in South Africa will be obese (Omoruyi and Durojaye 106). At the same time, worldwide malnutrition continues to rise, with one in every three people suffering from it (Priyadarsini and Sireesha 893). Researchers further warn that “youth still lack access to a balanced diet due to inadequate nutrition education, excessive junk food marketing, lack of healthy food options, and lax enforcement of food laws” (Priyadarsini and Sireesha 893). These alarming statistics demonstrate how deeply marketing influences public well-being and highlight why examining aggressive marketing is essential. Aggressive marketing strategies, such as emotional manipulation, targeted advertising, and deceptive messaging, are widely used in today’s consumer landscape, but they should be reconsidered due to their harmful psychological effects on consumers, their role in promoting overconsumption, and the ethical dilemmas they raise about moral integrity and consumer rights.

Before delving too deeply into this analysis, it is essential to understand the basics of marketing. At its core, marketing is the process by which businesses communicate the value of their products or services to potential customers. As Paul Henry explains in an article written on Work on Peak, marketing strategies are designed to expand a company’s customer base,

strengthen brand recognition, and ultimately increase sales (Henry). Dr. Rankin shares in an article that, in this way, marketing serves as a bridge between producers and consumers, shaping not only what people notice but also how they interpret and experience those perceptions (Rankin). It is a powerful social tool that influences cultural trends, consumer behavior, and even public health outcomes.

While traditional marketing focuses on informing and persuading, aggressive marketing takes these efforts further by relying on bold, highly visible, and proactive tactics intended to make a strong impression quickly. Henry notes that aggressive marketing often employs psychological triggers such as scarcity, authority, and social proof to influence consumer choices (Henry). These tactics are designed to bypass rational decision-making and instead appeal to emotions, urgency, or social pressure. For example, limited-time offers create a sense of scarcity, celebrity endorsements establish authority, and testimonials provide social proof that a product is desirable.

The distinction between standard marketing and aggressive marketing lies in the intensity and intent of the strategies used. Standard marketing looks to build long-term relationships with consumers, while aggressive marketing prioritizes immediate impact, often at the expense of consumer well-being. Rankin emphasizes that marketing does not simply shape what is perceived, but the very process of perception itself (Rankin). When aggressive tactics are employed, this influence can become manipulative, distorting consumer judgment and encouraging behaviors such as overconsumption.

To fully understand the consequences of aggressive marketing, it is beneficial to examine how these strategies have been applied in industries that directly impact public health. Two of the

most prominent examples are the nicotine market and the food industry, both of which exemplify how manipulative advertising can shape consumer behavior and endanger vulnerable populations. The tobacco industry has long relied on aggressive marketing to normalize and glamorize nicotine use. Sharma and her team explain that “tobacco companies deliberately designed campaigns to make smoking appear fashionable and socially desirable, while simultaneously concealing its health risks” (Sharma et al. 1). These campaigns often misled the public by suggesting that products were harmless or even FDA-approved, despite the agency’s active resistance to nicotine marketing (Sharma et al. 2–3). Youth audiences were especially targeted through flavored products, colorful packaging, and advertisements that portrayed smoking or vaping as trendy and rebellious (Sharma et al. 3). Such tactics illustrate how aggressive marketing can exploit impressionable groups, encouraging behaviors that carry lifelong health consequences.

Aggressive marketing is equally pervasive in the food industry, particularly in campaigns directed at children. Priyadarsini and Sireesha note that youth nutrition continues to suffer due to excessive advertising of junk food, digital campaigns, and influencer promotions that glamorize fast food and sugary snacks (892–894). Omoruyi and Durojaye add that “food and beverage marketing to children appears across nearly every medium; television, magazines, billboards, digital platforms, schools, and even sponsored events” (108). These advertisements rely on visually stimulating strategies such as cartoon characters, bright packaging, catchy jingles, and celebrity endorsements to make unhealthy products appear fun and desirable (108–109). Television ads, in particular, encourage consumption of ultra-processed foods and sugary drinks, often airing during programs aimed at children and families (109). The parallels between the nicotine and food industries are striking. Both rely on emotional manipulation, deceptive

messaging, and youth-targeted campaigns to secure sales. In each case, aggressive marketing prioritizes profit over public health, creating environments where unhealthy choices are normalized and even celebrated.

Building on these examples, the problems aggressive marketing creates for vulnerable audiences become clear. Food advertisements frequently present misleading health claims that distort consumer understanding. Omoruyi and Durojaye found that “of 582 food advertisements, 45% contained health and nutrient content claims... These claims were significantly higher in unhealthy food advertisements compared to healthy food” (110). Breakfast cereals, for instance, often highlight fiber content while ignoring high sugar and salt levels, creating the impression of a balanced product when the reality is far less nutritious ( Omoruyi and Durojaye 110). A study of South African supermarkets revealed that “95% of breakfast cereals carried health or nutrition claims despite being low in protein and fiber and high in sugar” ( Omoruyi and Durojaye 110). These deceptive practices contribute to poor dietary choices and long-term health risks among children.

Aggressive marketing also exploits psychological vulnerabilities. Rankin explains that “advertisements relying on fear can increase stress and anxiety, leading individuals to avoid certain behaviors” (Rankin). Exposure to idealized images in advertising “decreases self-esteem and increases anxiety and depression, particularly among younger audiences” (Rankin). Emotional appeals, whether happiness, fear, or anger, distort perception and decision-making, leaving consumers more likely to make choices that do not align with their best interests. Social media intensifies these effects by constantly exposing users to manipulative, emotionally charged content, further lowering self-esteem and fueling unrealistic expectations (Rankin).

Misleading advertising intensifies these issues by creating long-term preferences for unhealthy products. Priyadarsini and Sireesha note that “even with robust legislation India still faces issues with youth nutrition, including unequal access to food, deceptive advertising, lax enforcement, and low knowledge” (896). Similarly, Omoruyi and Durojaye argue that “advertising unhealthy foods to children undermines healthy eating habits and influences family purchasing decisions” (106–107). These findings demonstrate how misleading marketing not only affects individual choices but also shapes consumption patterns, embedding unhealthy habits into cultural norms. Taken together, these health, psychological, and ethical concerns reveal the profound impact aggressive marketing has on vulnerable audiences. By exploiting weaknesses in knowledge, perception, and emotions, advertisers create environments where unhealthy and manipulative choices dominate, leaving lasting consequences for public health and consumer rights.

Given these consequences, scholars and policymakers have argued for stricter regulation of aggressive marketing practices. Sharma and her associates emphasize that “these findings highlight the need to closely monitor business marketing to help regulate ONP marketing” (3). Priyadarsini and Sireesha propose that “accountability can be improved via a National Youth Nutrition Commission, more stringent advertising laws, and a nutrition ombudsman” (897). Stronger food labeling regulations are also seen as essential. Priyadarsini and Sireesha argue that “prohibitions on child-targeted junk food advertisements, and nutrition instruction in schools are all necessary to promote kid nutritional health as a sustainable consumer right” (897). Omoruyi and Durojaye add that “ongoing advocacy for the South African government to adopt better food labelling (Front-of-Pack Warning Labels) and advertising regulations... aims to introduce front-of-pack warning labels as well as impose restrictions on the use of health/nutrition claims

and marketing to children” (107). These proposed solutions highlight the importance of accountability and transparency in marketing. By enforcing stricter regulations, governments can help protect vulnerable populations from manipulative advertising and ensure that consumer rights are upheld. The evidence suggests that without such measures, aggressive marketing will continue to exploit psychological weaknesses, mislead consumers, and contribute to long-term health problems.

The evidence makes clear that aggressive marketing reaches far beyond ordinary persuasion, shaping consumer behavior in ways that compromise health, as well as moral integrity. From nicotine companies that glamorized harmful products while hiding their risks (Sharma et al. 1–3), to food industries that bombard children with colorful, misleading advertisements (Omoruyi and Durojaye 108–109), these strategies exploit psychological vulnerabilities and normalize unhealthy choices. As a result, young people face rising rates of malnutrition, obesity, and emotional distress. Scholars across multiple fields agree that stronger regulation is necessary, arguing for improved labeling laws, stricter advertising limits, and greater accountability from corporations (Priyadarsini and Sireesha 897; Omoruyi and Durojaye 107). Ultimately, aggressive marketing strategies, rooted in emotional manipulation, targeted campaigns, and deception, must be reevaluated because they harm consumers psychologically, encourage unhealthy overconsumption, and raise serious ethical concerns about consumer rights. As Omoruyi and Durojaye remind us, “children are growing up in an obesogenic food environment... states have been urged to protect children’s health and well-being” (106–107). Together, these voices are a call to action, to demand accountability, protect the vulnerable, and ensure that future generations inherit a food and health system built on dignity, truth, and sustainability.

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